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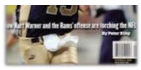


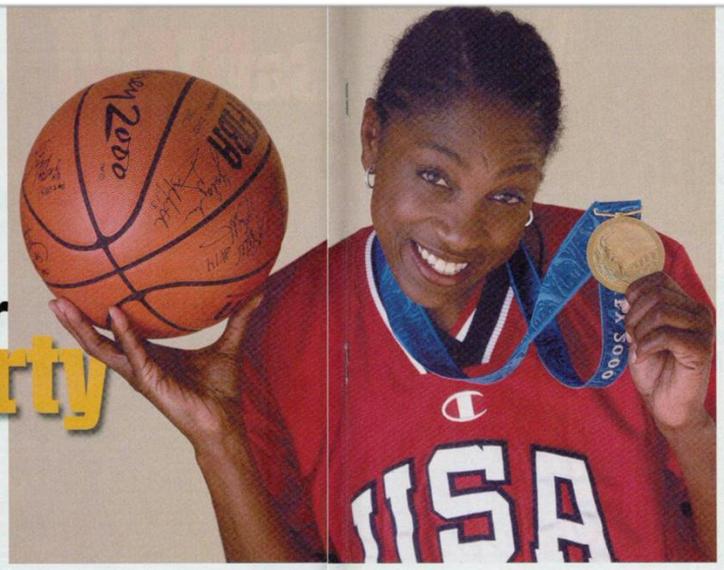
Sports Illustrated , October 9, 2000, Volume 93, No.14 (p. 60-61)

GOLDEN GALLERY

Teresa Edwards may not have next, but she does have a fourth Olympic title as testament to her unyielding will

Another T Party

BY ALEXANDER WOLFF



THERE'S GUY to her game. It shows when she thunderclaps a free hand to a rebound or drops off a no-look pass to a teammate in traffic, but Teresa Edwards's androgynous brand of basketball can best be seen between the foul lines. That's where she'll pour herself down the floor, rolling her shoulders to deceptive effect, looking off a frosh Pole or Slovak or Aussie, always with the game in front of her.

In fact, basketball is largely behind her now. The gold medal the U.S. women won with a 76-54 defeat of Australia—it came as effortlessly as their 36-year-old floor leader can make the game seem—was Edwards's fourth, to go with a bronze she won in 1992. Afterward she sat alone and still in the center circle of the Sydney Superdome, lingering so long that U.S. guard Dawn Staley, fearing Edwards had lost her mind, came out of the stands, where she was celebrating with family, to look after her. "I was just trying to steal a moment for myself," Edwards explained later. "I kind of wanted to be the last one to walk off the court."

To be the last one off means something in the winners-hold-court precincts where Edwards learned the game, with the guys in a park in Cairo, Ga. "You don't see all of T when she plays with women," says Staley, who has joined Edwards for some of those games. Adds Ruthie Bolton-Holifield, another U.S. teammate, "Her whole game changes when she plays with guys. With guys, she's ballin'."

If you failed to stumble across the 5' 11" Edwards in one of the four foreign pro leagues in which she has played, or were never hip to the speakeasies where elite women's college ball could be found during her days at Georgia in the early 1980s, you're not alone in your deprivation. Edwards was rarely seen on TV before the Olympics in Atlanta four years ago, and in the ensuing years could be spotted only during the brief passage of the American Basketball League. Alone among the dozen women on the U.S. team, Edwards has never played in the WNBA, the league that snuffed out the ABL in December 1998. The NBA ladies' auxiliary classified all ABL refugees as rookies and forced them to accept its rookie salary scale. Edwards sat out the '99 WNBA season in protest. A year later she asked for nothing more than what she had received in the ABL—$150,000, according to reports, or $200,000 if she could have a say in where she played. (The highest-paid players in the WNBA last season reportedly earned salaries of $150,000.) "Even what the top 10 percent of the WNBA players make is pennies to my mind," she says, "and I would have taken less. Feeling like I was begging for less. I shouldn't have to beg."

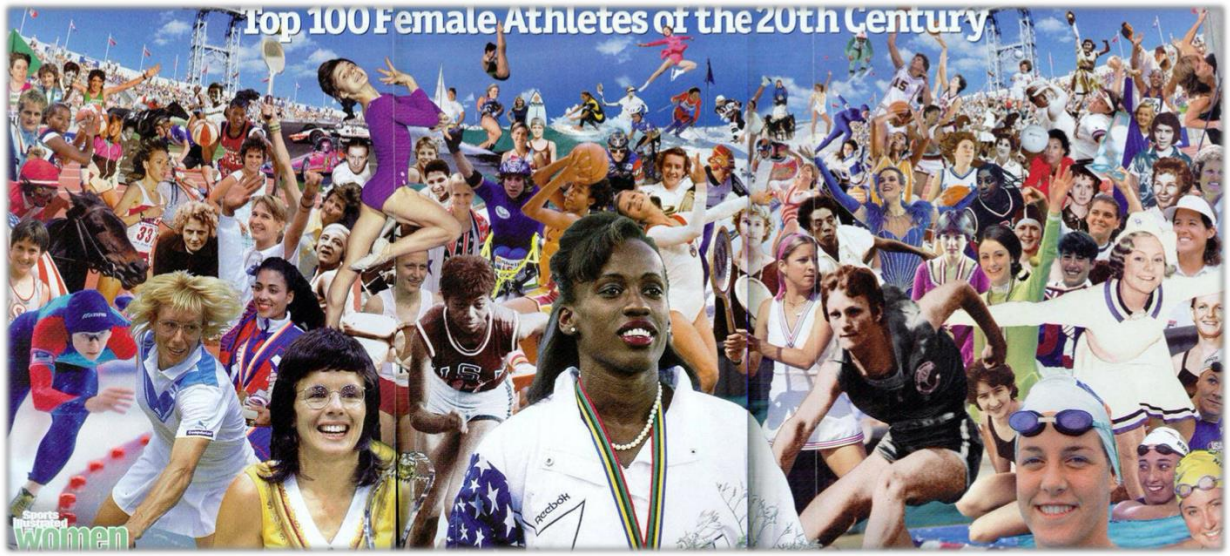
So while her national teammates mustered with their WNBA clubs last spring and summer, Edwards hung with the guys. From April through August she ran the track at Atlanta's Grady High, lifted weights at a downtown fitness club and played pickup with the buppies and former college players, all male, who populate a gym in uptown Buckhead. There, *we got next* isn't a facile promotional slogan but an invocation that allowed her to keep her game sharp enough to win gold. Indeed, messages piling up from her pickup buddies last week made it clear: A man's ego suffers less from being beaten by a woman when some golden purpose is served by his humiliation.

Last Saturday night, fingering her latest gold medal, Edwards batted away suggestions that she had come along too soon. "I think I was right on time," she said. "I think I've left a mark, etched something somewhere that people will remember me by." She also foresaw any bitter feeling toward the WNBA: "You can't miss what you never had. I can stand for the end of something. They can stand for the beginning of something. Whatever that something is, we'll figure out someday."

Call her stubborn, but after five Olympics—no other American basketball player has ever competed in more than three—a headstrong champion has earned the right to be called something else. Better to call her willful. All hail the noble, willful warrior. All hail Elle Syd. ☐

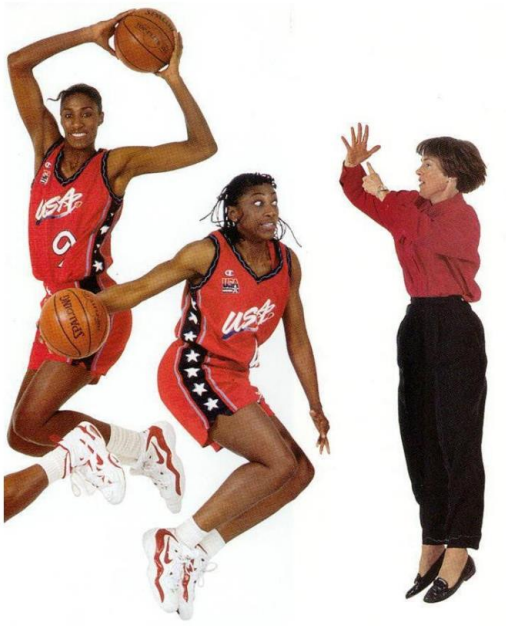
60 SPORTS ILLUSTRATED

PHOTOGRAPH BY BILL FRAKES

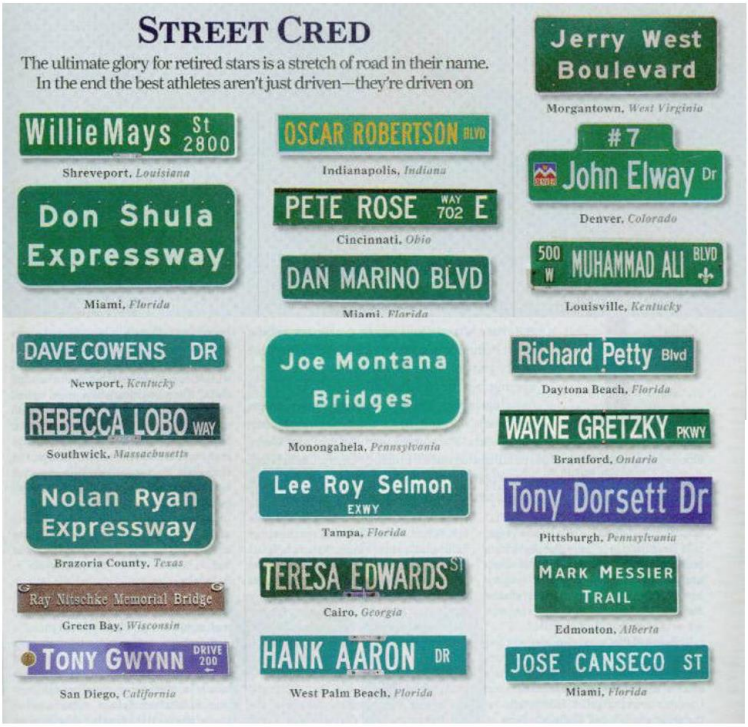


Sports Illustrated , Winter 1999-2000,
Number 4 (p. 76-78)

Sports Illustrated
July 22, 1996



You Go, Girls!
The U.S. Women's Basketball Team
(From left: Sheryl Swoopes, Katrina McClain, Ruthie Bolton, Lisa Leslie, Teresa Edwards, coach Tara VanDerveer)



Sports Illustrated , July 2-9, 2007, Volume 107, No.1 (p. 110-111)

real life

★YOUR FOOD★

SALAD DAYS Unlike many elite athletes, Teresa Edwards of the U.S. women's hoops team loves veggies, raw or cooked.

Olympic Feasts

Active women—from gold medalists to gym rats—have one thing in common: They need to eat better. Here's how you can improve on your personal best in nutrition

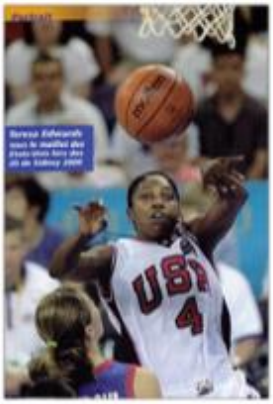
BY BERNADETTE SUKLEY

TERESA EDWARDS, a U.S. Olympic basketball star, sheepishly admits she loves her vegetables. "I know it sounds weird, but I'm a Southern girl—I like collard greens, okra, squash and green beans," says the 5'11" point guard. That's only the start of her good eating habits. Edwards also follows a balanced diet. "I listen to *my* body," says the 36-year-old five-time Olympian. "I always make sure I eat at least two healthy meals a day. And I never eat too much of anything."

SPORTS ILLUSTRATED FOR WOMEN / 51

Sukley, Bernadette. "Olympic Feasts." Sports Illustrated for Women Sept/Oct 2000: 51.

INTERNATIONAL MAGAZINES:



Portrait

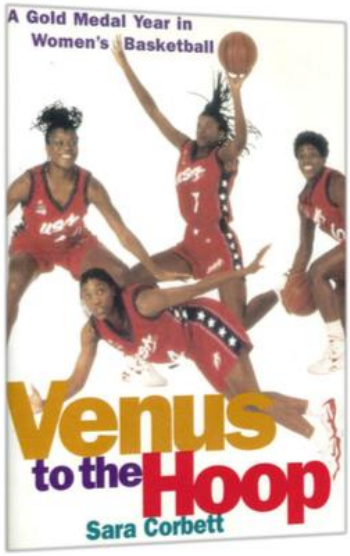
Teresa Edwards

(Valenciennes)

Basket Feminin, March 2002, Volume 2 (p. 16-17)

Sport Sztar, February 9-15, 2000, Volume 3 Issue 6(p. 24-25)

BOOKS THAT INCLUDES TERESA are Below Here:



These women on whom so much pressure rested included a runway model (who also happened to be one of the few women players able to dunk), a forward who barely survived a car accident that left her in a coma, a collegiate sensation struggling to live up to her rep and her huge marketing contract from Reebok, a superstar known as "the female Michael Jordan," and a controversial, unrelenting coach. Nine of the women were black; three were white. Some were married, some single; some outspoken, some painfully shy. Some were rivals, some fast friends. How they came together, both on and off the court, is the subject of this wonderful celebration of the female athlete.

SARA CORBETT enjoyed exclusive access to the gold medal–winning U.S.A. Basketball Women's National Team throughout 1995–96. She has written for magazines such as *Outside* and *Self* and is currently a senior contributing editor at the new *Condé Nast Sports for Women*. She lives in Bridgton, Maine.

Corbett, Sara. Venus to the Hoop: A Gold Medal Year in Women's Basketball . New York, NY: Double Day, 1998.

"Having Visions" Excerpt p. 17

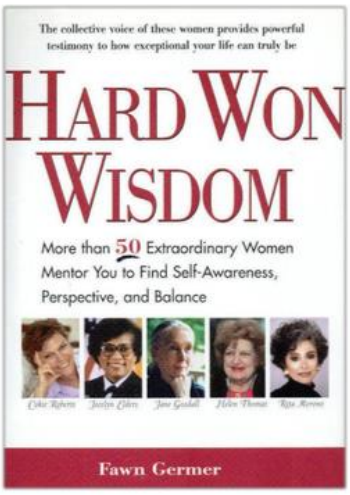
"As a kid, I was told to prepare for the worst as well as the best. I was prepared for what the world wouldn't give me. I knew I had to go out and make it happen. I accept my gift for what it is, my strengths for what they are. I'm not going to be Michael Jordan, because that's not me. This is who I am.
I think women are better at accepting our strengths and making the most of them. Men get in mind what they want to be and what they want to hap pen. and hen it doesn't happen, they are devastated."

-Teresa Edwards. Olympic champion, pioneer of women's basketball

"Playing with the Old Boys' Club" Excerpt p. 110-111

So, I asked women's basketball champion Teresa Edwards about competing with men on the court. What she describes sounds a lot like the usual dynamics of a routine day at work. "Men think that anytime they are challenged by women, it is questioning their manhood," she said. "To this day, men have trouble with being beaten by women. Even if they never played organized basketball, in their mind, there is still no way a female is going to beat them. That's incredible to me."

Hmmm. What's the difference between how a man and a woman loses? "I don't think they (men) deal with losing very well," she said. "When they aren't able to achieve the level they want to achieve, it haunts them for a long time. Women move on or find another way to get where we are trying to go. When I play a man, I don't try to strip his male pride. I want him to know that we, as women, are capable of beating men, but it doesn't have to be a male-female thing. It can just be between me, Teresa, and whoever else it is. I say jokingly, 'I'll make sure to leave you with your manhood. But, I am going to win this game.'" She always laughs as she says it, and says warning them ahead of time makes a loss easier to take. Plus, that lighter atmosphere makes them less likely to push and shove and be rough on the court because they are angry that they are behind and getting desperate to win. "I just take the game and go. They get a kick out of it."
Women don't have to be men, she said. "Our bodies and our minds are different," she said. "That's been proven time and time again. Strength is not in the size of your muscles. I think God made men stronger physically. I agree with that. I don't think I should get in the weight room and try to be stronger than a man. I should get in the weight room and be as strong as I can be."



Germer, Fawn. Hard Won Wisdom. New York: The Berkley Publishing Group, 2001.

"Playing with the Old Boys' Club" Excerpt p. 117

I look at Teresa Edwards, who has been called the "female Michael Jordan," who pioneered the American Basketball League and won gold medals at five Olympic games. Michael Jordan was paid more for one game than Edwards made in a couple of years, but she didn't let herself become consumed by bitterness. Instead, she found other rewards. "We get so much less in terms of the dollar figures, yet we give so much more in terms of passion," she said. "Personally, I get what I need. I can't really worry what everyone else is getting. I'm going to fulfill my desires when I go out and perform. I think we get more balance out of life." It's not about money or power,
but rather, who we are. "It's not a man's world anymore," she said. "It's our world. All of our world."

"Getting a Life" Excerpt p. 248

"We know the meaning of life. It is not a $50 million contract for seven years. That's not the meaning of life. The hardest thing to teach is that peace of mind is so much more important than the biggest bank account. You have to be the best you can possibly be
on this earth, and you have to grow as a person:'

-Women's basketball legend Teresa Edwards

"Turning Criticism into Opportunity" Excerpt p. 158

Basketball superstar Teresa Edwards said she can't perform her best on a team without knowing everybody else's strengths and weaknesses and playing to them.
"Acknowledge your weaknesses,"
she said. "Work on them. The one person who thinks they don't have weaknesses will hurt your team before the person who has weaknesses." The hard part, for her, was getting others to know their own weaknesses so they could grow past them.

PORTRAITS
TERESA EDWARDS

Laura Sikes

GROWING UP in Cairo, Georgia, Teresa Edwards spent little time with other girls; they were interested in cheerleading, while she ran in track meets and played softball and basketball. "Whatever the boys did, I did," recalls Edwards. "My mother killed me for it, but I'd go back out every day anyway." In most sports, she just held her ground, but in basketball, she was better than the boys. At twelve, she made the junior high school team. Playing for Cairo High School, she led her team to a state title her senior year.

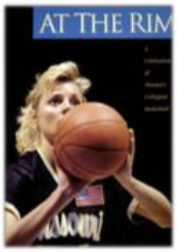
Offered numerous basketball scholarships, Edwards chose the University of Georgia, where she received her B.S. in recreation in 1989. The intensely competitive 5'11" guard scored a career high of 40 points in a game against Tennessee her senior year; four days later, LSU held her to 12 points, but she managed 15 rebounds, another career high.

Edwards is the University of Georgia's all-time leader in assists (653) and steals (342) and ranks third on the school's all-time scoring records. In her four years, Georgia had a 116-17 record, won three Southeastern Conference championships, and reached the Women's Final Four twice. She is a Kodak All-American and was a gold medalist in the 1984 and 1988 Olympics and the 1987 Pan Am Games.

Six months of the year, Edwards plays on a professional team in Japan. "I feel like a stranger there, but I enjoy basketball so much that I'll play it anywhere," says Edwards, who is the first American guard hired to play on a Japanese team. She admires the Japanese players' quickness and strength as well as their work ethic.

"I've tried to help my teammates get more enjoyment out of our games," she says, "but the Japanese have taught me that it doesn't necessarily have to be fun." She misses American fans and the collegiate atmosphere. "We never had sellouts, but there were always the faithful few who would show up. The fans helped all of us feel good about what we were doing."

She recalls Georgia coach Andy Landers with special admiration. "He was always in charge, and he worked us very hard. Some kids will run from that," she ponders. But not Edwards, who says she would like to be somewhat like him when she turns to college coaching in the coming years.



Eastman Kodak Company and Thomasson-Grant . At the Rim: A Celebration of Women's Collegiate Basketball. Professional Photography Division, 1991. (p.181)

TERESA EDWARDS
UNIVERSITY OF GEORGIA
1983-1986

ONE OF THE MOST RESPECTED players in international women's basketball history, Teresa Edwards first put on a USA uniform at the age of 17 and remained a fixture on USA Basketball teams for almost 20 years.

The first basketball player, male or female, to have played in five Olympics, Edwards also etched her name in the history books as the youngest recipient of an Olympic gold medal in women's basketball (age 20 in 1984) and the oldest (age 36 in 2000). She was selected to carry the United States flag during the 1996 Olympics in Atlanta. The four-time USA Basketball Female Athlete of the Year has been a member of 22 different USA Basketball teams, winning 14 gold, one silver and three bronze medals.

With the talented guard on the roster, USA teams compiled an overall record of 205-14, for a 93.6 winning percentage. A two-time All-American at the University of Georgia, Edwards led her team to two Final Fours, three SEC Championships and a 116-17 overall record. She is one of only three players in the history of the UGA women's basketball program to have her jersey retired.

The most decorated player in the history of the USA Basketball Women's Team, Teresa Edwards' exciting style of play created a surge in the popularity of the women's game.

Southeastern Conference . SEC Seventy-Fifth Anniversary 1933-2008 . Birmingham, AL: EBSCO Media , 2008 . (p. 43)

TERESA EDWARDS, BASKETBALL, 1984-96
"THE BIGGEST THING IN MY LIFE"

"I didn't choose basketball," Teresa Edwards readily tells those chronicling her great career — a career that even today is not showing any signs

an incredible 116-17 record. As a 5-11, 155-pound backcourt ace known simply as "T," she twice led Georgia into the NCAA Final Four. The Bulldogs cap-

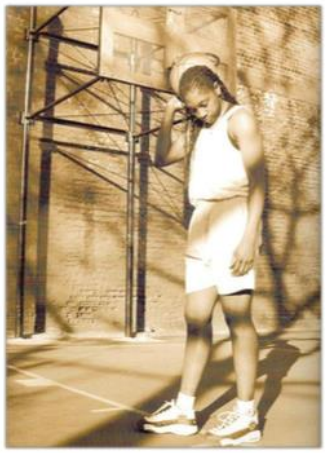
in assists and steals and was third in scoring with a 12.6 average.

As Teresa heads into her fourth Olympic Games, she holds numerous

TERESA

EDWARDS

the most decorated player in women's basketball
the only four-time u.s. basketball olympian
three-time winner, u.s.a. basketball's female athlete of the year



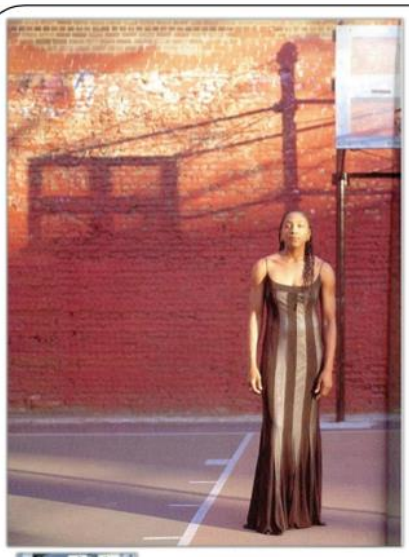
Teresa Edwards's shoot was less than perfect. The flight was overbooked, the time was late, the address was wrong, hotel reservations were lost, and my twelve-foot ladder didn't fit in my ten-foot rental van. Sometimes it happens—a bad day—but Teresa was not only a good sport, she agreed to my every photographic whim and answered all of my questions without even a pause to wonder. Her discipline inspired me. "Christina, I see what you're trying to do, and we're going to do whatever it takes to get it done." It was obvious that getting the job done was this tremendous athlete's theme. Among her many accomplishments, Edwards played an instrumental role in the formation of the American Basketball League, and after two years with the Atlanta Glory (playing and coaching), she joined the Philadelphia Rage in the fall of 1999.

Basketball has always been the thrill of my life. As a child, I was a natural athlete. In most sports I held my own, but in basketball I flew. I didn't choose basketball, I believe it chose me. I know God gave this gift to me, and I use it to the best of my ability every day. Basketball is my drug, it feeds me and gives me everything I need. I get a high out of passing, shooting, outrunning my opponents, playing defense. Right now my life is surrounded by it, and I pray that my future will be too. I'm trying to do the best that I can while I'm here, and after this life is over and I have to answer to God, we will both know that giving back has been most important to me. He has his own plan for all of us, and that includes the arena of women's sports. I do feel that women's time on the playing field has come. It's a new day for sports, and it's a great day.

I grew up in a small town in Georgia called Cairo, a southern town where everyone knows everyone else. It was a nice place to grow up slow. I'm in my thirties and it still hasn't changed. I'm the oldest of five and the only girl. My brothers and I all played together, creating whatever we could think of. When you don't have a lot of money you become inventors. We'd make drums out of cardboard and have parades in the street. People would watch us from their porches and laugh. In my mind I can still hear and see these things. It was a good childhood.

When you come from a small town it's hard to realize that the same opportunities exist for you as for everyone else, so you can really get stuck. You have to make your own opportunities happen. It became my goal to inspire others and to be an example. I wanted to let kids know that they needed to get out and see the world. If kids could see the world's different cultures—even just the different cultures in the United States—they might want more out of life, to go beyond their local boundaries. I'm fortunate—somehow I made it out of there. I became successful at basketball, but not many other kids have followed me and that makes me sad because I always try to be a role model, a positive influence, a leader.

Lessa, Christina. Women Who Win: Stories of Triumph in Sport and Life . New York, NY : Universe Publishing, 1998 .
(p. 8-9)



afterword by TERESA EDWARDS

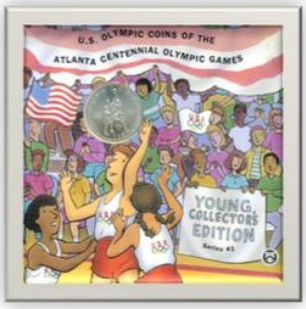
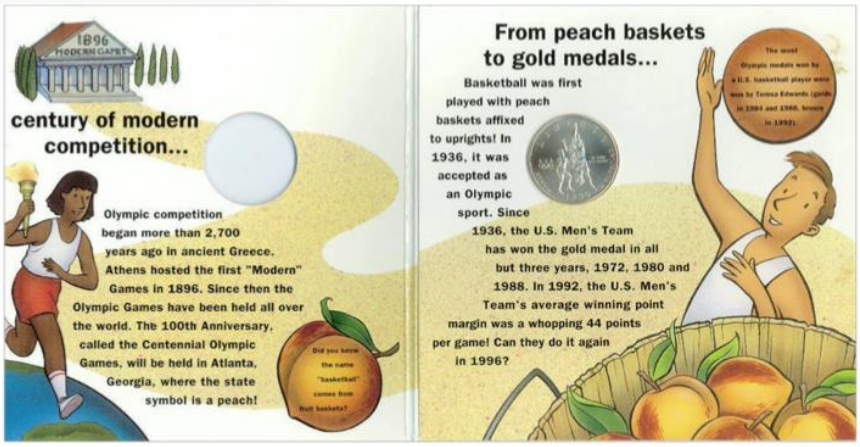
What is it that defines a true athlete?
What is it that makes female athletes unique?
What is it that separates world-class from average?
These are the ideals presented in *Women Who Win*. The fine athletes in this collection were chosen not only for their accomplishments in sports, but also for their pioneering spirit in fields otherwise dominated by men. It's amazing to think that the women's basketball leagues are only in their beginning seasons and that the women's soccer team is about to compete in its first World Cup. The hockey team, without a league of its own, has just won gold at its first Olympic games. Not so long ago, there was no ABL and I had to play abroad in order to live my dream of being a professional player. Like many of the stories in this book, mine is one of persistence, devotion, and sacrifice—qualities that characterize professional female athletes.

Overall, these are stories of celebration—what makes a woman and her athleticism endure and evolve. These could have been stories of anger and frustration, but they are not. Instead, they are stories of strength: the power of leadership in the face of adversity; the importance of mentors, role models, and people who give children the boost they need to rise; the inescapable influence of our parents.

The athletes in this book are women who shape their own existence, their own goals—they teach us what true sportsmanship is all about. It is humbling to think about the women who have come before us, born into difficult circumstances and conflicting expectations and told to live inside the boundaries. Yet somehow they bravely went outside them, rewriting the assumptions and conventions that told them who they should become.

As an athlete, it makes me proud to think that the story I share with other women in sports will ultimately bring inspiration and satisfaction to the lives of others for years to come.

Edwards, Teresa. Afterward. Women Who Win: Stories of Triumph in Sport and Life . By Christina Lessa. New York, NY: Universe Publishing, 1998 .
(p. 12; 152)



US Mint. US Olympic Coins of the Atlanta Centennial Olympic Games: Young Collector's Edition Series #1. 1994.